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On the Expected Coprime Density of the Least Common Multiple of Random Integers

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Abstract

Let $X_1, X_2, \ldots$ be independent and identically distributed random variables uniform on $\{2, 3, \ldots, M\}$, and let $L_k = \operatorname{lcm}(X_1, \ldots, X_k)$. We study the expected coprime density

$$\rho_k(M) = \mathbb{E}\left[\frac{\varphi(L_k)}{L_k}\right],$$

where φ is the Euler totient function. We establish an exact finite-sum identity for $\rho_k(M)$, written as a sum over subsets of primes $p \leq M$ and obtained by Möbius inversion on the subset lattice. The identity implies $\rho_k(M) \to P_M := \prod_{p \leq M}(1 - 1/p)$ as $k \to \infty$ with M fixed, with a sharp asymptotic equivalence $\rho_k(M) - P_M = P_M \Sigma_k(M)(1 + o(1))$ at geometric rate, where $\Sigma_k(M) = \sum_{p \leq M} q_p(M)^k/(p-1)$ and $q_p(M) = 1 - \lfloor M/p \rfloor/(M-1)$. In the joint regime $k = \lfloor cM \rfloor$, $M \to \infty$ (fixed $c > 0$), we prove the full asymptotic equivalence

$$\ln M \cdot \frac{\rho_{\lfloor cM \rfloor}(M) - P_M}{P_M} \longrightarrow A(c) := \sum_{j \geq 1} e^{-cj} \ln\left(1 + \tfrac{1}{j}\right),$$

strengthening the leading-order statement to an $o(1)$ remainder via a geometric-mean inequality for subset densities. Numerical computation to $M = 10^7$ across 15 values of $c \in [0.05, 15]$ illustrates the finite-M behaviour; linear extrapolation in $1/\ln M$ agrees with $A(c)$ to within approximately 0.5% for $c \in [0.1, 5]$ and 1.5% over the full tested range. The regime of fixed M and growing k is complementary to the fixed-k, $M \to \infty$ regime of the existing literature on random LCMs.

Keywords: Random LCM, Euler totient, Mertens product, Meissel–Mertens constant, probabilistic number theory, coprime density, Möbius inversion, Rosser–Schoenfeld bounds.
MSC 2020: 11N37, 11K65, 11A25.

1 Introduction

The least common multiple of random integers is a classical object. Cesàro [4] showed that the expected LCM of two integers drawn uniformly from $\{1, \ldots, n\}$ is asymptotic to $n^2\zeta(3)/\zeta(2)$ as $n \to \infty$. The subject has seen substantial recent development. Cilleruelo, Rué, Šarka, and Zumalacárregui [5] established almost-sure asymptotics for $\log \operatorname{lcm}$ of random subsets of $\{1, \ldots, n\}$; Fernández and Fernández [6] surveyed divisibility properties of random tuples; Hilberdink and Tóth [7] obtained the average value of lcm of k integers; Alsmeyer, Kabluchko, and Marynych [1] proved limit theorems for $\log \operatorname{lcm}$ of random sets; Bostan, Marynych, and Raschel [2] established

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distributional convergence of $f(L_n(k))/n^{r_k}$ for multiplicative functions f of polynomial growth, where $L_n(k) = \mathrm{lcm}(X_1, \ldots, X_k)$ with X_i uniform on $\{1, \ldots, n\}$ and k fixed as $n \to \infty$; Buraczewski, Iksanov, and Marynych [3] established a central limit theorem for $\log \mathrm{lcm}$ of a uniformly sampled m-tuple; Iksanov, Marynych, and Raschel [8] extended to hyperbolic regions; Kabluchko, Marynych, and Raschel [9] to broader domains; and Sanna [13] to q-analogues. A dissection of Mertens' prime product formula along a different axis (number of prime factors of summand integers) was given by Lichtman [10].

These works share a common regime: the support size n grows while the number of samples k stays bounded. In this paper we study the opposite and complementary regime: the support $\{2, \ldots, M\}$ is fixed and the number of samples $k \to \infty$, plus the diagonal regime $k = \lfloor cM \rfloor$ with $M \to \infty$. The natural object of study in this regime is not the LCM itself — which almost surely equals $\mathrm{lcm}(1, \ldots, M)$ for large k — but the arithmetic function

$$\frac{\varphi(L_k)}{L_k} = \prod_{p \mid L_k} \left(1 - \frac{1}{p}\right),$$

which measures the density of integers coprime to L_k. This quantity takes values in $(0, 1]$ and its large-k behaviour is governed by exactly which primes $p \leq M$ appear as divisors of L_k. One expects the Mertens product as the limit, and this paper makes that expectation precise with explicit convergence rates. Second-order fluctuations — the variance asymptotic and a central limit theorem for the centred log coprime density — are developed in separate work in preparation.

1.1 Main results

Throughout, $M \geq 2$ is a fixed integer, $X_1, X_2, \ldots$ are i.i.d. uniform on $\{2, 3, \ldots, M\}$, $L_k = \mathrm{lcm}(X_1, \ldots, X_k)$, and $\rho_k(M) = \mathbb{E}[\varphi(L_k)/L_k]$. Write $\mathcal{P}_M = \{p : p \leq M\}$, $m_p = \lfloor M/p \rfloor$, and $q_p(M) = 1 - m_p/(M-1)$, the probability that a single uniform draw from $\{2, \ldots, M\}$ is not a multiple of p. For $T \subseteq \mathcal{P}_M$, let

$$\beta_T(M) = \frac{1}{M-1} \left| \left\{ n \in \{2, \ldots, M\} : \gcd\left(n, \textstyle\prod_{p \in T} p\right) = 1 \right\} \right|.$$

The Mertens product up to M is $P_M := \prod_{p \leq M}(1 - 1/p)$.

Theorem 1 (Exact identity)**.** *For every $M \geq 2$ and every $k \geq 1$,*

$$\rho_k(M) = P_M \sum_{T \subseteq \mathcal{P}_M} \beta_T(M)^k \prod_{p \in T} \frac{1}{p-1}. \tag{1}$$

Theorem 2 (Limit and rate)**.** *Let $\Sigma_k(M) := \sum_{p \leq M} q_p(M)^k/(p-1)$ and $\Lambda(M) := \sum_{p \leq M} 1/(p-1)$. For every fixed $M \geq 2$, $\lim_{k \to \infty} \rho_k(M) = P_M$, and*

$$\frac{\rho_k(M) - P_M}{P_M} = \Sigma_k(M) + R_k(M), \tag{2}$$

where $R_k(M) \geq 0$ satisfies

$$R_k(M) \leq \frac{1}{2} \Sigma_{k/2}(M)^2 \, e^{\Lambda(M)}. \tag{3}$$

In particular $R_k(M) \to 0$ and $\Sigma_k(M) \to 0$ as $k \to \infty$, establishing $\rho_k(M) \to P_M$.

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Remark 3. The bound (3) establishes $R_k(M) \to 0$ at exponential rate at fixed M, but as an asymptotic equivalence it gives only $R_k(M) = O(\Sigma_{k/2}(M)^2)$, which at fixed M is $O(1) \cdot \Sigma_k(M)$ rather than $o(1) \cdot \Sigma_k(M)$. The sharper conclusion does *not* follow from (3) alone; in particular it would follow from the naïve independence bound $\beta_T(M) \le \prod_{p \in T} q_p(M)$, which however fails in a non-trivial set of small-M examples. For instance, at $M = 17$ and $T = \{3, 5\}$ one has $\beta_T = 9/16$ while $q_3 q_5 = 143/256$, with excess $1/256 \approx 3.9 \times 10^{-3}$; the worst violation we observed over $M \le 50$ is $1/90 \approx 1.1 \times 10^{-2}$, at $M = 31$, $T = \{2, 3, 7\}$. Theorem 4 below obtains the sharp equivalence by a different, simpler route.

Theorem 4 (Sharp form at fixed M)**.** *For every fixed $M \ge 3$, as $k \to \infty$,*

$$\frac{R_k(M)}{\Sigma_k(M)} = O\left(\left(\frac{q^{**}(M)}{q^*(M)}\right)^k\right), \tag{4}$$

where $q^*(M) := \max_{p \le M} q_p(M)$ and $q^{**}(M) := \max_{T \subseteq \mathcal{P}_M, |T| \ge 2} \beta_T(M)$ satisfy $q^{**}(M) < q^*(M)$. In particular $R_k(M) = o(\Sigma_k(M))$ as $k \to \infty$, and

$$\rho_k(M) - P_M = P_M \, \Sigma_k(M) \, \big(1 + o(1)\big) \qquad (k \to \infty, \ M \text{ fixed}).$$

Moreover, for $M \ge 11$, elementary enumeration shows there are at least two primes in $(M/2, M]$ (a consequence of Ramanujan's strengthening of Bertrand's postulate [11]), giving $q^{**}(M) = (M-3)/(M-1)$ and $q^*(M) = (M-2)/(M-1)$, so that $q^{**}(M)/q^*(M) = (M-3)/(M-2)$ and the rate of convergence is explicit.

Theorem 5 (Joint scaling, sharp form)**.** *For each fixed $c > 0$,*

$$\lim_{M \to \infty} \ln M \cdot \Sigma_{\lfloor cM \rfloor}(M) = A(c), \tag{5}$$

where

$$A(c) := \sum_{j \ge 1} e^{-cj} \ln\left(1 + \frac{1}{j}\right), \tag{6}$$

and moreover

$$\lim_{M \to \infty} \ln M \cdot \frac{\rho_{\lfloor cM \rfloor}(M) - P_M}{P_M} = A(c). \tag{7}$$

The leading-order assertion (5) is established via Mertens' second theorem, Rosser–Schoenfeld bounds, and dominated convergence. The sharp form (7) requires a genuinely new ingredient: a geometric-mean bound for subset densities (Lemma 10 below) that controls the multi-prime correction R_k uniformly.

Proposition 6 (Asymptotic behaviour of A)**.** *The function $A\colon (0, \infty) \to (0, \infty)$ is smooth, strictly decreasing, and strictly convex. Moreover:*

(i) As $c \to 0^+$,

$$A(c) = -\ln c - \gamma - \frac{c \ln c}{2} + O(c),$$

where γ is the Euler–Mascheroni constant.

(ii) As $c \to \infty$,

$$A(c) = e^{-c} \ln 2 + e^{-2c} \ln \tfrac{3}{2} + e^{-3c} \ln \tfrac{4}{3} + O(e^{-4c}).$$

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1.2 Organisation

Section 2 fixes notation and records elementary lemmas, including the new geometric-mean bound Lemma 10. Sections 3, 4, 5, and 6 prove Theorems 1, 2, 4, and 5 respectively. Section 7 presents numerical evidence. Section 8 discusses the fluctuations problem and other extensions. Section 9 concludes.

2 Preliminaries

Notation is standard: φ is Euler's totient, p ranges over primes, $\mathcal{P}(n) = \{p : p \mid n\}$, and $\mathcal{P}_M = \{p : p \le M\}$. We use ln (natural logarithm) throughout; the Mertens product is $P_M = \prod_{p \le M}(1 - 1/p)$.

For $p \in \mathcal{P}_M$, every multiple of p in $\{1, \dots, M\}$ also lies in $\{2, \dots, M\}$ since $p \ge 2$, so $m_p = \lfloor M/p \rfloor$ equals the number of multiples of p in the sampling space. For $T \subseteq \mathcal{P}_M$, let $A_T(M) = \{n \in \{2, \dots, M\} : \gcd(n, \prod_{p \in T} p) = 1\}$, so $\beta_T(M) = |A_T(M)|/(M-1)$, $\beta_\emptyset(M) = 1$, and $\beta_{\{p\}}(M) = q_p(M)$.

Lemma 7. *For any $T \subseteq \mathcal{P}_M$,*

$$\mathbb{P}\big(\forall i \le k,\ X_i \in A_T(M)\big) = \beta_T(M)^k,$$

equivalently, $\mathbb{P}(\text{no prime in } T \text{ divides } L_k) = \beta_T(M)^k$.

Proof. Immediate from independence of $X_1, \dots, X_k$ and the fact that $p \mid L_k$ iff $p \mid X_i$ for some i. □

Lemma 8. *For any $\emptyset \ne T \subseteq \mathcal{P}_M$ and any $p_0 \in T$, $\beta_T(M) \le q_{p_0}(M)$.*

Proof. $A_T(M) \subseteq \{n \in \{2, \dots, M\} : p_0 \nmid n\}$. □

Lemma 9 (Two-prime bound for $|T| \ge 2$)**.** *Let $T \subseteq \mathcal{P}_M$ with $|T| \ge 2$, and let p_0, p_1 be any two distinct elements of T. Then for every $k \ge 1$,*

$$\beta_T(M)^k \le q_{p_0}(M)^{k/2}\, q_{p_1}(M)^{k/2}.$$

Proof. By Lemma 8 applied to each of p_0, p_1, $\beta_T(M)^{k/2} \le q_{p_0}(M)^{k/2}$ and $\beta_T(M)^{k/2} \le q_{p_1}(M)^{k/2}$. Multiply. □

Lemma 10 (Geometric-mean bound for $|T| \ge 1$)**.** *Let $T \subseteq \mathcal{P}_M$ with $|T| = r \ge 1$. For every real $k > 0$,*

$$\beta_T(M)^k \le \prod_{p \in T} q_p(M)^{k/r}. \tag{8}$$

Proof. By Lemma 8, $\beta_T(M) \le q_p(M)$ for every $p \in T$. Multiplying these r inequalities gives $\beta_T(M)^r \le \prod_{p \in T} q_p(M)$, and taking both sides to the positive real power k/r preserves the inequality since both sides lie in $(0, 1]$. Rewriting the right-hand side as $\prod_{p \in T} q_p(M)^{k/r}$ gives (8). □

Remark 11. Lemma 10 is the key new ingredient for the sharp form (7) of Theorem 5. Lemma 9 suffices for (5) at leading order but forces an $O(1)$ remainder via the factor $e^{\Lambda(M)}$ in (3). The stronger bound (8) permits a stratification of the multi-prime sum by $|T|$ that avoids the wasteful $e^{\Lambda(M)}$ factor, at the cost of using $\Sigma_{k/r}$ rather than $\Sigma_{k/2}$ for terms with $|T| = r \ge 3$.

Remark 12. The naïve bound $\beta_T(M) \le \prod_{p \in T} q_p(M)$, which would be valid under independence, fails in general: for instance at $(M, T) = (17, \{3, 5\})$ direct enumeration gives $\beta_T = 9/16 \approx 0.5625$ while $q_3 q_5 = (11/16)(13/16) = 143/256 \approx 0.5586$. The failure arises because the events $\{p \mid X\}$ for different primes p are not independent on the finite sample space $\{2, \dots, M\}$. Lemma 10 provides the alternative bound actually needed for the proof of Theorem 5.

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3 Proof of Theorem 1

For each $S \subseteq \mathcal{P}_M$, let $E_S = \{\mathcal{P}(L_k) = \mathcal{P}_M \setminus S\}$ be the event that the set of primes dividing L_k is exactly $\mathcal{P}_M \setminus S$. On E_S,

$$\frac{\varphi(L_k)}{L_k} = \prod_{p \in \mathcal{P}_M \setminus S} \left(1 - \frac{1}{p}\right) = \frac{P_M}{\prod_{p \in S}(1 - 1/p)} = P_M \prod_{p \in S} \frac{p}{p-1}. \tag{9}$$

The events $\{E_S\}_{S \subseteq \mathcal{P}_M}$ partition the sample space (primes $> M$ never divide any X_i), so

$$\rho_k(M) = P_M \sum_{S \subseteq \mathcal{P}_M} \mathbb{P}(E_S) \prod_{p \in S} \frac{p}{p-1}. \tag{10}$$

Now $E_S = \{\text{no prime in } S \text{ divides } L_k\} \cap \{\text{every prime in } \mathcal{P}_M \setminus S \text{ divides } L_k\}$, so by Möbius inversion on the subset lattice,

$$\mathbb{P}(E_S) = \sum_{T\colon S \subseteq T \subseteq \mathcal{P}_M} (-1)^{|T|-|S|}\, \mathbb{P}(\text{no prime in } T \text{ divides } L_k) = \sum_{T \supseteq S} (-1)^{|T|-|S|}\, \beta_T(M)^k, \tag{11}$$

by Lemma 7. Substituting (11) into (10) and swapping the order of summation,

$$\rho_k(M) = P_M \sum_{T \subseteq \mathcal{P}_M} \beta_T(M)^k \sum_{S \subseteq T} (-1)^{|T|-|S|} \prod_{p \in S} \frac{p}{p-1}.$$

The inner sum factors over primes in T:

$$\sum_{S \subseteq T} (-1)^{|T|-|S|} \prod_{p \in S} \frac{p}{p-1} = \prod_{p \in T} \left(\frac{p}{p-1} - 1\right) = \prod_{p \in T} \frac{1}{p-1}.$$

4 Proof of Theorem 2

Starting from (1) and isolating $T = \emptyset$ (contribution P_M),

$$\frac{\rho_k(M) - P_M}{P_M} = \sum_{T \subseteq \mathcal{P}_M,\, T \neq \emptyset} \beta_T(M)^k \prod_{p \in T} \frac{1}{p-1}.$$

The $|T| = 1$ contributions sum to $\Sigma_k(M)$. Denote the sum of the $|T| \geq 2$ contributions by $R_k(M)$.

To bound $R_k(M)$, group each T with $|T| \geq 2$ by its two smallest primes. For each pair $\{p_0, p_1\}$ with $p_0 < p_1 \in \mathcal{P}_M$, let $\mathcal{T}(p_0, p_1) = \{T \subseteq \mathcal{P}_M : \min T = p_0,\ \text{second-min}\, T = p_1\}$. Then every T with $|T| \geq 2$ lies in exactly one such class, and $T \in \mathcal{T}(p_0, p_1)$ iff $T = \{p_0, p_1\} \cup U$ for some $U \subseteq \mathcal{P}_M \cap (p_1, \infty)$. By Lemma 9,

$$\begin{aligned} R_k(M) &= \sum_{p_0 < p_1 \in \mathcal{P}_M} \sum_{T \in \mathcal{T}(p_0,p_1)} \beta_T(M)^k \prod_{p \in T} \frac{1}{p-1} \\ &\leq \sum_{p_0 < p_1} \frac{q_{p_0}(M)^{k/2}}{p_0 - 1} \cdot \frac{q_{p_1}(M)^{k/2}}{p_1 - 1} \sum_{U \subseteq \mathcal{P}_M \cap (p_1, \infty)} \prod_{p \in U} \frac{1}{p-1} \\ &\leq \sum_{p_0 < p_1} \frac{q_{p_0}(M)^{k/2}}{p_0 - 1} \cdot \frac{q_{p_1}(M)^{k/2}}{p_1 - 1} \cdot e^{\Lambda(M)}, \end{aligned}$$

using $\sum_U \prod_{p \in U} 1/(p-1) = \prod_{p \leq M}(1 + 1/(p-1)) \leq e^{\Lambda(M)}$. The inequality $\sum_{p_0 < p_1} a_{p_0} a_{p_1} \leq \frac{1}{2}(\sum_p a_p)^2$ with $a_p = q_p(M)^{k/2}/(p-1)$ gives (3).

For the limit: each $q_p(M) < 1$ and $\mathcal{P}_M$ is finite, so $\Sigma_k(M) \to 0$ as $k \to \infty$; and $\Sigma_{k/2}(M) \to 0$ similarly, so $R_k(M) \to 0$ by (3). Hence $(\rho_k(M) - P_M)/P_M \to 0$, i.e. $\rho_k(M) \to P_M$. □

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5 Proof of Theorem 4

Recall $R_k(M) = \sum_{T \subseteq \mathcal{P}_M, |T| \geq 2} \beta_T(M)^k \prod_{p \in T} \frac{1}{p-1}$.

Step 1: $q^{**}(M) < q^*(M)$ for $M \geq 3$. Fix any $T \subseteq \mathcal{P}_M$ with $|T| \geq 2$ and pick distinct $p_0, p_1 \in T$. By Lemma 8, $\beta_T(M) \leq q_{p_0}(M) \leq q^*(M)$. We show the first inequality is strict, which gives $\beta_T < q^*$.

Strict inclusion $A_T(M) \subsetneq A_{\{p_0\}}(M)$ holds because p_1 itself, viewed as an integer in $\{2, \ldots, M\}$, belongs to $A_{\{p_0\}}(M) \setminus A_T(M)$: indeed p_1 is coprime to p_0 (distinct primes) so $p_1 \in A_{\{p_0\}}(M)$, but p_1 is divisible by $p_1 \in T$ so $p_1 \notin A_T(M)$. Hence $|A_T| < |A_{\{p_0\}}|$, i.e. $\beta_T < q_{p_0}$. Since this holds for every T with $|T| \geq 2$, $q^{**}(M) < q^*(M)$.

Step 2: bound on R_k. For every T with $|T| \geq 2$, $\beta_T \leq q^{**}$, so

$$R_k(M) = \sum_{|T| \geq 2} \beta_T^k \prod_{p \in T} \frac{1}{p-1} \leq (q^{**})^k \sum_{|T| \geq 2} \prod_{p \in T} \frac{1}{p-1}.$$

The last sum is at most $\prod_{p \leq M}(1 + 1/(p-1)) = \prod_{p \leq M} p/(p-1) = 1/P_M \leq e^{\Lambda(M)}$ (Mertens). Hence

$$R_k(M) \leq (q^{**}(M))^k \cdot e^{\Lambda(M)}. \tag{12}$$

Step 3: lower bound on Σ_k. Let p^* be any prime with $q_{p^*}(M) = q^*(M)$. Then

$$\Sigma_k(M) \geq \frac{(q^*(M))^k}{p^* - 1} \geq \frac{(q^*(M))^k}{M-1}. \tag{13}$$

Step 4: combining. Dividing (12) by (13),

$$\frac{R_k(M)}{\Sigma_k(M)} \leq (M-1)\, e^{\Lambda(M)} \left(\frac{q^{**}(M)}{q^*(M)} \right)^k.$$

Since $q^{**} < q^*$ (Step 1), the right-hand side tends to 0 geometrically in k, establishing (4).

Step 5: explicit rate for $M \geq 11$. For $M \geq 11$, by Ramanujan's strengthening of Bertrand's postulate [11] there are at least two primes in $(M/2, M]$; call them p_1, p_2. Both have $m_p = 1$, so $q_{p_i} = (M-2)/(M-1) = q^*$. For $T = \{p_1, p_2\}$, $p_1 p_2 > (M/2)^2 \geq M$ (for $M \geq 4$), so $\lfloor M/(p_1 p_2) \rfloor = 0$ and $\beta_T = (M - 2 - 2 + 0 - 1)/(M-1) = (M-3)/(M-1)$ by direct inclusion-exclusion. To see this is the maximum: any other T with $|T| \geq 2$ satisfies either (i) $T \subseteq \mathcal{P}_M \cap (M/2, M]$, in which case $\beta_T = (M - |T| - 1)/(M-1) \leq (M-3)/(M-1)$ since $|T| \geq 2$; or (ii) T contains some p with $m_p \geq 2$, in which case $\beta_T \leq q_p \leq (M-3)/(M-1)$ (since $q_p = 1 - m_p/(M-1) \leq (M-3)/(M-1)$). Hence $q^{**}(M) = (M-3)/(M-1)$. □

6 Proof of Theorem 5

We prove (5) first and then derive (7) from Lemma 10.

6.1 Proof of (5): leading-order convergence of Σ

Partition primes by m_p-value. A prime p satisfies $m_p = j$ iff $p \in (M/(j+1), M/j]$. For such p, $q_p(M) = 1 - j/(M-1)$. Write

$$S_j(M) := \sum_{p \in \mathcal{P}_M :\, m_p = j} \frac{1}{p-1},$$

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so $\Sigma_{\lfloor cM \rfloor}(M) = \sum_{j\geq 1}(1 - j/(M-1))^{\lfloor cM \rfloor} S_j(M)$.

Pointwise limit. For each fixed $j \geq 1$, using $\ln(1-x) = -x + O(x^2)$ as $x \to 0$,

$$\big(1 - j/(M-1)\big)^{\lfloor cM \rfloor} = \exp\big(\lfloor cM \rfloor(-j/(M-1) + O(1/M^2))\big) \longrightarrow e^{-cj}.$$

By the prime number theorem with a classical de la Vallée Poussin error term [14, Ch. I.3], partial summation yields the sharpened form of Mertens' second theorem

$$\sum_{p\leq x} \frac{1}{p} = \ln\ln x + \beta_1 + E(x), \qquad E(x) = O\big(\exp(-\alpha\sqrt{\ln x})\big),$$

uniformly in $x \geq 2$, where $\beta_1 \approx 0.2615$ is the Meissel–Mertens constant and $\alpha > 0$ is an absolute constant (unrelated to the regime parameter c); in particular $E(x) = o(1/\ln x)$. Applying this at $x = M/j$ and $x = M/(j+1)$ (which requires $M/(j+1) \geq 2$, i.e. $j \leq M/2 - 1$),

$$\sum_{p\in(M/(j+1),\, M/j]} \frac{1}{p} = \ln\frac{\ln(M/j)}{\ln(M/(j+1))} + E(M/j) - E(M/(j+1)). \tag{14}$$

For each fixed $j \geq 1$, the error term is $o(1/\ln M)$ as $M \to \infty$. A first-order expansion gives

$$\ln\frac{\ln M - \ln j}{\ln M - \ln(j+1)} = \frac{\ln(1+1/j)}{\ln M}\big(1 + O_j(1/\ln M)\big).$$

The discrepancy between $\sum 1/(p-1)$ and $\sum 1/p$ over the same interval is $\sum 1/(p(p-1))$, which at $p \in (M/(j+1), M/j]$ is bounded by (interval length)/(smallest p)$^2 \leq (j+1)^2/(M\ln(M/(j+1)))$, hence of order $O(1/(Mj\ln M)) = o(1/\ln M)$. Multiplying (14) by $\ln M$ and taking $M \to \infty$ at fixed j,

$$\ln M \cdot S_j(M) \longrightarrow \ln(1+1/j) \qquad (M \to \infty) \tag{15}$$

for each fixed j.

Uniform tail bound.

Lemma 13 (Uniform envelope)**.** *For all $M \geq 289$ and all $1 \leq j \leq M/17$,*

$$S_j(M) \leq \frac{5.04}{\ln(M/j)}.$$

In particular, for $1 \leq j \leq M^{1/2}$ and $M \geq 289$, $\ln M \cdot S_j(M) \leq 10.08$ uniformly in j.

Proof. By the Rosser–Schoenfeld explicit bounds [12], for $x \geq 17$, $\pi(x) \leq 1.26\, x/\ln x$; the hypothesis $j \leq M/17$ ensures $M/j \geq 17$. Hence the number of primes in $(M/(j+1), M/j]$ is at most $\pi(M/j) \leq 1.26(M/j)/\ln(M/j)$. Each such prime satisfies $p > M/(j+1) \geq M/(2j)$ (using $j \geq 1$), and for $M \geq 4j$ this gives $p - 1 \geq M/(4j)$, so $1/(p-1) \leq 4j/M$ uniformly over the interval (the hypothesis $j \leq M/17$ implies $M \geq 17j \geq 4j$). Therefore

$$S_j(M) \leq \pi(M/j) \cdot \frac{4j}{M} \leq 1.26 \cdot \frac{M/j}{\ln(M/j)} \cdot \frac{4j}{M} = \frac{5.04}{\ln(M/j)}.$$

For $j \leq M^{1/2}$, $\ln(M/j) \geq \frac{1}{2}\ln M$, giving $\ln M \cdot S_j(M) \leq 10.08$. □

Dominated convergence. Combining the pointwise limit (15) with the envelope Lemma 13 and the inequality $(1 - j/(M-1))^{\lfloor cM \rfloor} \le 2e^{-cj}$ (valid uniformly for $1 \le j \le M^{1/2}$ and $M \ge M_1(c)$), each term in the main range is bounded by $2 \cdot 10.08\, e^{-cj}/\ln M$, and multiplied by $\ln M$ the envelope $20.16\, e^{-cj}$ is summable in j. The tail $j > M^{1/2}$ contributes at most

$$\sum_{j>M^{1/2}} \big(1 - j/(M-1)\big)^{\lfloor cM \rfloor} S_j(M) \le \Lambda(M)\,\big(1 - M^{-1/2}\big)^{\lfloor cM \rfloor} = O\big(\ln\ln M \cdot e^{-c\sqrt{M}/2}\big),$$

which is super-polynomially small (and $\Lambda(M) = \sum_p 1/(p-1) = O(\ln\ln M)$ by Mertens). By dominated convergence,

$$\ln M \cdot \Sigma_{\lfloor cM \rfloor}(M) \longrightarrow \sum_{j\ge 1} e^{-cj} \ln(1 + 1/j) = A(c). \quad \square$$

6.2 Proof of (7): the sharp form

Because of (5), it suffices to show $\ln M \cdot R_k(M) \to 0$ in the joint regime:

$$\lim_{M\to\infty} \ln M \cdot R_k(M) = 0, \qquad k = \lfloor cM \rfloor. \tag{16}$$

Size decomposition. Group $R_k(M)$ by $|T|$:

$$R_k(M) = \sum_{r\ge 2} R_k^{(r)}(M), \qquad R_k^{(r)}(M) := \sum_{T\subseteq \mathcal{P}_M,\, |T|=r} \beta_T^k \prod_{p\in T} \frac{1}{p-1}.$$

Bound for each fixed $r \ge 2$. By Lemma 10, $\beta_T^k \le \prod_{p\in T} q_p^{k/r}$ for $|T| = r$. Hence

$$R_k^{(r)}(M) \le \sum_{T:\, |T|=r} \prod_{p\in T} \frac{q_p^{k/r}}{p-1} = e_r\left(\left\{\tfrac{q_p^{k/r}}{p-1}\right\}_{p\in\mathcal{P}_M}\right) \le \frac{\Sigma_{k/r}(M)^r}{r!}, \tag{17}$$

where e_r denotes the r-th elementary symmetric polynomial and we used the standard inequality $e_r(x_1, \dots, x_n) \le (x_1 + \cdots + x_n)^r/r!$ for nonnegative x_i.

By applying the leading-order claim (5) with c replaced by c/r, we have

$$\ln M \cdot \Sigma_{k/r}(M) \longrightarrow A(c/r) \qquad (M \to \infty), \tag{18}$$

uniformly in the sense that the argument of Section 6.1 applies verbatim with c replaced by c/r, noting that the sequence $k/r = \lfloor cM \rfloor/r$ differs from $\lfloor (c/r)M \rfloor$ by at most one unit, which changes $q_p^{k/r}$ by a bounded multiplicative factor. (Strictly, (5) was stated for integer exponents; the real-exponent version follows since q_p^s depends continuously on s and all bounds above go through with real s.)

Combining (17) and (18), for each fixed $r \ge 2$,

$$\ln M \cdot R_k^{(r)}(M) \le \frac{(\ln M \cdot \Sigma_{k/r}(M))^r}{r!\,(\ln M)^{r-1}} \longrightarrow \frac{A(c/r)^r}{r! \cdot \infty} = 0. \tag{19}$$

Tail bound for $|T| > R$. For any integer $R \ge 2$, using Lemma 8 in the weak form $\beta_T \le q_{\min}(M) := \min_{p\le M} q_p(M) = q_2(M)$,

$$\sum_{r>R} R_k^{(r)}(M) \le q_{\min}(M)^k \sum_{r>R} \sum_{T:\, |T|=r} \prod_{p\in T} \frac{1}{p-1} \le q_{\min}(M)^k\, e^{\Lambda(M)}.$$

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Since $q_2(M) = 1 - \lfloor M/2 \rfloor/(M-1) \le 1/2 + 1/(M-1)$, for all $M \ge M_1$ we have $q_{\min}(M) \le 3/5$ say, so $q_{\min}^k \le (3/5)^{cM}$; and $e^{\Lambda(M)} = O(\ln M)$ by Mertens' third theorem. Hence

$$\ln M \cdot \sum_{r>R} R_k^{(r)}(M) = O\big((\ln M)^2\,(3/5)^{cM}\big) \longrightarrow 0 \tag{20}$$

as $M \to \infty$, uniformly in $R \ge 2$.

Conclusion. Fix $\varepsilon > 0$. By (20), there exists $M_2 = M_2(\varepsilon, c)$ such that $\ln M \cdot \sum_{r>2} R_k^{(r)} \le \varepsilon/2$ for all $M \ge M_2$ (taking $R = 2$). Equivalently,

$$\ln M \cdot R_k(M) \le \ln M \cdot R_k^{(2)}(M) + \varepsilon/2 \quad \text{for } M \ge M_2.$$

By (19) at $r = 2$, there exists $M_3 = M_3(\varepsilon, c) \ge M_2$ such that $\ln M \cdot R_k^{(2)}(M) \le \varepsilon/2$ for $M \ge M_3$. Therefore $\ln M \cdot R_k(M) \le \varepsilon$ for $M \ge M_3$, proving (16).

(Alternatively, the argument truncates at any fixed R: $\ln M \cdot \sum_{r=2}^{R} R_k^{(r)} \to 0$ as a finite sum of terms each tending to zero by (19), and the tail $r > R$ is controlled by (20).)

Combining with (5),

$$\ln M \cdot \frac{\rho_k - P_M}{P_M} = \ln M \cdot \Sigma_k + \ln M \cdot R_k \longrightarrow A(c) + 0 = A(c),$$

which is (7). □

Proof of Proposition 6. Smoothness of A on $(0, \infty)$ follows from term-by-term differentiation of the uniformly convergent series (6). The first two derivatives are

$$A'(c) = -\sum_{j\ge1} j\, e^{-cj} \ln(1 + 1/j), \quad A''(c) = \sum_{j\ge1} j^2\, e^{-cj} \ln(1 + 1/j),$$

both with every term positive, so $A'(c) < 0$ (strict monotonicity) and $A''(c) > 0$ (strict convexity) for all $c > 0$.

Proof of (ii). Isolating the first three terms of (6) and using $\ln(1 + 1/j)$ is decreasing in j,

$$A(c) - e^{-c}\ln 2 - e^{-2c}\ln\tfrac{3}{2} - e^{-3c}\ln\tfrac{4}{3} = \sum_{j\ge4} e^{-cj}\ln(1+1/j) \le \ln\tfrac{5}{4}\sum_{j\ge4} e^{-cj} = \frac{\ln(5/4)}{1-e^{-c}}\, e^{-4c},$$

which is $O(e^{-4c})$ as $c \to \infty$ since $1/(1 - e^{-c}) \to 1$.

Proof of (i). For every $j \ge 1$, the alternating Taylor series $\ln(1 + x) = \sum_{k\ge1}(-1)^{k+1}x^k/k$ at $x = 1/j$ gives

$$\ln(1 + 1/j) = \frac{1}{j} - \frac{1}{2j^2} + R(j), \qquad |R(j)| \le \frac{1}{3j^3}, \tag{21}$$

where the bound on $R(j)$ is the alternating-series remainder. Substituting into (6) and separating the three resulting convergent series,

$$A(c) = -\ln(1 - e^{-c}) - \tfrac{1}{2}\,\mathrm{Li}_2(e^{-c}) + \sum_{j\ge1} e^{-cj} R(j), \tag{22}$$

where $\sum_{j\ge1} e^{-cj}/j = -\ln(1 - e^{-c})$ and $\sum_{j\ge1} e^{-cj}/j^2 = \mathrm{Li}_2(e^{-c})$.

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The sum $\sum_{j\geq 1} R(j)$ converges absolutely by (21). Since $\sum_{j=1}^{N} \ln(1+1/j) = \ln(N+1)$ (telescoping), $\sum_{j=1}^{N} 1/j = H_N = \ln N + \gamma + O(1/N)$, and $\sum_{j=1}^{N} 1/(2j^2) = \pi^2/12 + O(1/N)$,

$$\sum_{j=1}^{N} R(j) = \sum_{j=1}^{N} \big(\ln(1+1/j) - 1/j + 1/(2j^2)\big) = \ln(N+1) - H_N + \tfrac{1}{2}\sum_{j=1}^{N} 1/j^2,$$

which tends to $\pi^2/12 - \gamma$ as $N \to \infty$. Hence

$$\sum_{j\geq 1} R(j) = \frac{\pi^2}{12} - \gamma. \tag{23}$$

For the c-dependence of the third term in (22),

$$\sum_{j\geq 1} e^{-cj} R(j) - \sum_{j\geq 1} R(j) = -\sum_{j\geq 1} (1 - e^{-cj}) R(j),$$

whose absolute value is bounded, using $1 - e^{-cj} \leq cj$ and $|R(j)| \leq 1/(3j^3)$, by $(c/3)\sum_{j\geq 1} 1/j^2 = c\pi^2/18$. Hence

$$\sum_{j\geq 1} e^{-cj} R(j) = \frac{\pi^2}{12} - \gamma + O(c). \tag{24}$$

Finally, expand the first two terms of (22). From $1 - e^{-c} = c(1 - c/2 + O(c^2))$,

$$-\ln(1 - e^{-c}) = -\ln c - \ln(1 - c/2 + O(c^2)) = -\ln c + c/2 + O(c^2). \tag{25}$$

For the dilogarithm, the reflection identity $\mathrm{Li}_2(z) + \mathrm{Li}_2(1-z) = \pi^2/6 - \ln z \ln(1-z)$ gives, at $z = e^{-c}$,

$$\mathrm{Li}_2(e^{-c}) = \frac{\pi^2}{6} + c\ln(1 - e^{-c}) - \mathrm{Li}_2(1 - e^{-c}).$$

Using $\ln(1 - e^{-c}) = \ln c - c/2 + O(c^2)$ (from (25)) and $\mathrm{Li}_2(u) = u + u^2/4 + O(u^3)$ as $u \to 0$ with $u = 1 - e^{-c} = c - c^2/2 + O(c^3)$,

$$\mathrm{Li}_2(e^{-c}) = \frac{\pi^2}{6} + c\ln c - c - \frac{c^2}{4} + O(c^3). \tag{26}$$

Substituting (25), (26), and (24) into (22),

$$A(c) = \big[-\ln c + c/2\big] - \tfrac{1}{2}\big[\tfrac{\pi^2}{6} + c\ln c - c\big] + \big[\tfrac{\pi^2}{12} - \gamma\big] + O(c) = -\ln c - \gamma - \tfrac{c\ln c}{2} + O(c),$$

where the c-linear and c^2 remainders are absorbed into $O(c)$. □

7 Numerical Evidence

The theorems in Sections 3–6 are proved rigorously and require no numerical verification. The numerics below are included to illustrate the finite-M behaviour of the asymptotics in Theorems 2–5, which may be useful to readers who wish to work with these results computationally. In particular, the $O(1/\ln M)$ convergence in Theorem 5 is slow, and the tables below make the rate of convergence concrete. Computations and code supporting all figures and tables are openly available at the repository cited in Section 9.

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Computational protocol. All computations use exact integer arithmetic (Python's `sympy`) for φ and lcm. Monte Carlo estimates use NumPy's default PRNG seeded with fixed seed 2026. Exact values obtained from Theorem 1 are computed by direct enumeration over subsets $T \subseteq \mathcal{P}_M$.

Theorem 1. For $M \in \{5,6,7,8,9,10\}$ and $k \in \{2,3,4,5\}$, $\rho_k(M)$ computed via direct enumeration of all $(M-1)^k$ tuples was compared with the right-hand side of (1), using exact rational arithmetic throughout. All 23 test cases matched *exactly* as rationals. Against Monte Carlo (10^4 samples, standard error $\approx 10^{-3}$), agreement was within 2 standard errors.

Theorem 2. Figure 1 shows $\rho_k(M)$ versus k for $M \in \{100, 300, 1000\}$; Table 1 compares the observed gap $\rho_k(M) - P_M$ (Monte Carlo, $N = 2000$) with $P_M\,\Sigma_k(M)$ (computed exactly).

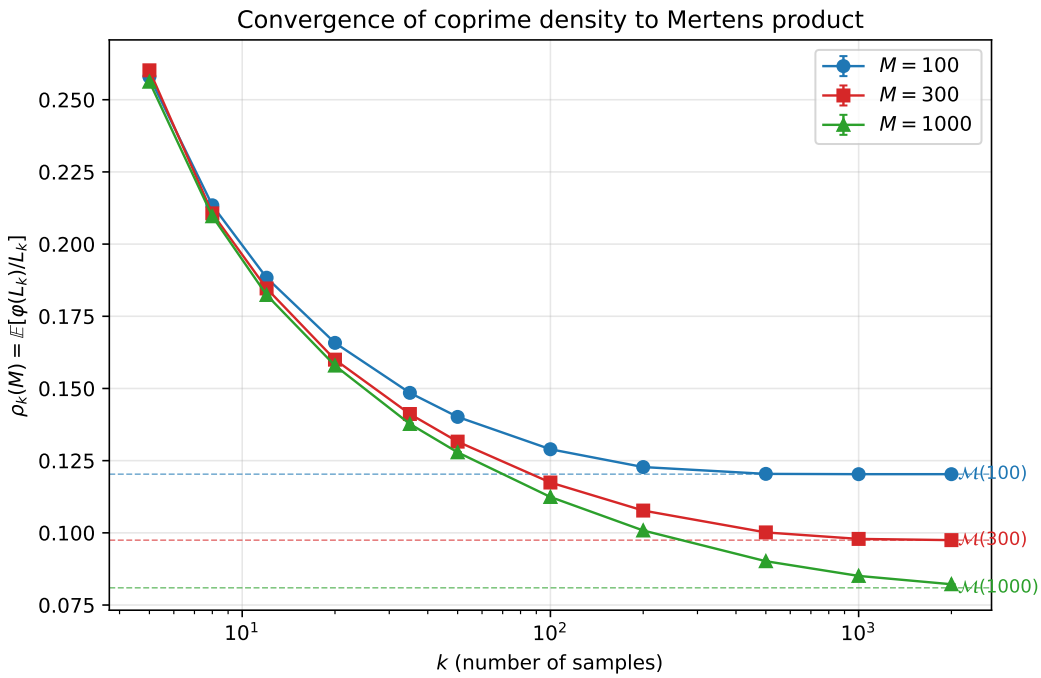

Figure 1: Monte Carlo estimates of $\rho_k(M)$ for $M \in \{100, 300, 1000\}$, based on $N = 2000$ independent replicates per point. Error bars show ± 1 standard error of the sample mean. Dashed lines indicate the exact Mertens product P_M.

Theorem 4 (sharp form at fixed M). Table 2 exhibits $R_k(M)/\Sigma_k(M)$ for $M \in \{20, 30\}$ and $k \in \{20, 40, 80, 160\}$ alongside the theoretical upper bound $(q^{**}/q^*)^k$ from Theorem 4 (ignoring the $(M-1)e^{\Lambda(M)}$ prefactor). The observed ratio decays exponentially, in fact substantially faster than the bound requires: at $M = 20$, the ratio falls from 4.5×10^{-2} at $k = 20$ to 1.2×10^{-5} at $k = 160$, while the bound predicts decay by factor $(17/18)^{140} \approx 3 \times 10^{-4}$.

Theorem 5. Figure 2 plots $\ln M \cdot \Sigma_{\lfloor cM \rfloor}(M)$ (computed exactly) at $M \in \{10^3, 10^4, 10^5, 10^6\}$ against $A(c)$; Table 3 extends to $M = 10^7$ across 15 values of $c \in [0.05, 15]$. The relative error $(\ln M \cdot \Sigma_{\lfloor cM \rfloor}(M) - A(c))/A(c)$ at $M = 10^7$ ranges from approximately 10.7% at $c = 0.05$ down to 2.1% at $c = 15$, decreasing monotonically in c; these residuals are consistent with the expected $O(1/\ln M)$ correction arising from the Meissel–Mertens constant in (14). Linear extrapolation of the sequence $\{\ln M \cdot \Sigma_{\lfloor cM \rfloor}(M)\}_M$ in the variable $1/\ln M$ (fitted over $M \in \{10^4, 10^5, 10^6, 10^7\}$) agrees with $A(c)$ to within approximately 0.5% for $c \in [0.1, 5]$ and to within 1.5% across the full tested range $c \in [0.05, 15]$.

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Table 1: Comparison of Monte Carlo estimates of $\rho_k(M) - P_M$ ($N = 2000$ samples per cell, standard error $\lesssim 10^{-3}$) against the first-order prediction $P_M \Sigma_k(M)$ computed exactly. The ratio column demonstrates convergence to unity as k grows, consistent with Theorem 2.

M	k	$\rho_k(M)$ (MC)	P_M (exact)	gap obs.	gap pred. (exact)	ratio
100	50	0.14023	0.12032	0.01991	0.01855	1.073
100	200	0.12280	0.12032	0.00248	0.00248	1.000
300	100	0.11740	0.09746	0.01994	0.01826	1.092
300	500	0.10013	0.09746	0.00267	0.00264	1.011
1000	500	0.09025	0.08097	0.00929	0.00876	1.060
1000	2000	0.08220	0.08097	0.00124	0.00122	1.016
1000	5000	0.08102	0.08097	0.00006	0.00006	1.000
3000	5000	0.07131	0.06997	0.00135	0.00133	1.015

Table 2: Observed ratio $R_k(M)/\Sigma_k(M)$ versus theoretical rate $(q^{**}(M)/q^*(M))^k$ from Theorem 4. The bound is not sharp but captures the exponential decay. For $M \geq 11$, $q^{**}/q^* = (M-3)/(M-2)$.

M	k	R_k/Σ_k (obs.)	$(q^{**}/q^*)^k$ (rate)
20	20	4.52×10^{-2}	3.19×10^{-1}
20	40	1.22×10^{-2}	1.02×10^{-1}
20	80	1.15×10^{-3}	1.03×10^{-2}
20	160	1.18×10^{-5}	1.07×10^{-4}
30	20	6.30×10^{-2}	4.83×10^{-1}
30	40	2.27×10^{-2}	2.34×10^{-1}
30	80	4.30×10^{-3}	5.45×10^{-2}
30	160	2.20×10^{-4}	2.97×10^{-3}

Table 3: $\ln M \cdot \Sigma_{\lfloor cM \rfloor}(M)$ versus $A(c)$ at M up to 10^7. All values computed exactly; no Monte Carlo. Residuals decay as expected from the $O(1/\ln M)$ Mertens-constant correction; see text.

c	$A(c)$	$M = 10^4$	$M = 10^5$	$M = 10^6$	$M = 10^7$
0.05	2.5267	3.0277	2.9231	2.8498	2.7982
0.10	1.9095	2.1999	2.1428	2.1009	2.0714
0.15	1.5688	1.7704	1.7324	1.7033	1.6831
0.25	1.1687	1.2886	1.2671	1.2498	1.2380
0.50	0.6954	0.7470	0.7382	0.7307	0.7258
0.75	0.4665	0.4950	0.4903	0.4861	0.4835
1.00	0.3301	0.3476	0.3448	0.3422	0.3406
1.25	0.2406	0.2522	0.2504	0.2486	0.2476
1.50	0.1787	0.1867	0.1855	0.1843	0.1836
2.00	0.1020	0.1061	0.1056	0.1049	0.1045
3.00	0.0356	0.0368	0.0367	0.0365	0.0364
5.00	0.00469	0.00485	0.00483	0.00480	0.00479
7.50	0.000384	0.000396	0.000395	0.000393	0.000392
10.00	0.0000315	0.0000325	0.0000324	0.0000322	0.0000321
15.00	0.00000021	0.00000022	0.00000022	0.00000021	0.00000021

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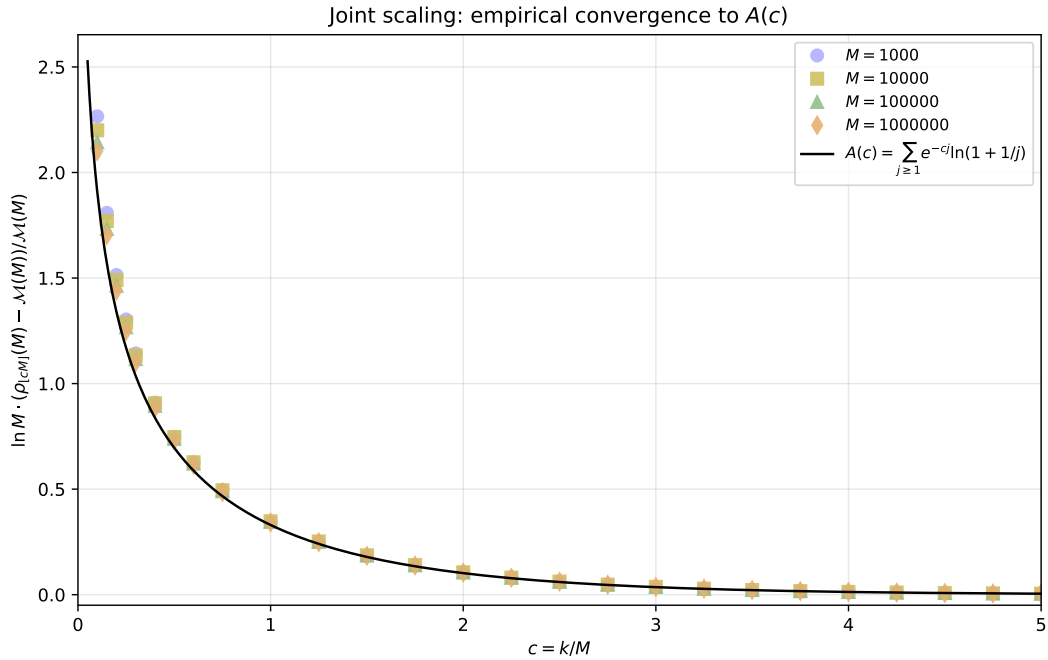

Figure 2: Joint scaling regime $k = \lfloor cM \rfloor$. Points show $\ln M \cdot \Sigma_{\lfloor cM \rfloor}(M)$, computed exactly (no Monte Carlo) at $M \in \{10^3, 10^4, 10^5, 10^6\}$. Solid curve: $A(c) = \sum_{j \geq 1} e^{-cj} \ln(1 + 1/j)$, computed to $j_{\max} = 200$.

8 Discussion and Open Problems

Uniform vs. non-uniform rates. Theorem 4 gives an exponential rate at fixed M, but the rate $q^{**}(M)/q^{*}(M) = (M-3)/(M-2) \to 1$ degenerates as $M \to \infty$, so the bound does not yield the sharp joint-scaling result of Theorem 5. The joint regime therefore requires a genuinely different mechanism (the geometric-mean bound Lemma 10).

Second-order fluctuations. A natural next question is the scale and distributional shape of the fluctuations of $\ln(\varphi(L_k)/L_k)$ about its mean in the same joint regime: the variance asymptotic and an associated central limit theorem. These are developed in separate work in preparation.

General distributions. Theorem 1 generalises verbatim to any distribution on $\{2, \ldots, M\}$, with $\beta_T(M)$ replaced by the probability of being coprime to $\prod_{p \in T} p$. Theorem 2 generalises similarly. The joint scaling (5) depends on the distribution of m_p-values, which is distribution-dependent.

Applications to non-uniform sampling diagnostics. For distributions close to uniform, the function $A(c)$ is robust, but substantial departures from uniformity deform it in a distribution-specific way. Empirical estimates of $A(c)$ could therefore serve as a statistical test of uniformity for random integer generators over bounded ranges; a systematic development is left to future work.

9 Conclusion

We have introduced the expected coprime density $\rho_k(M) = \mathbb{E}[\varphi(L_k)/L_k]$ of the LCM of random integers in the regime of fixed support and growing sample size, and proved four theorems and one proposition. Theorem 1 establishes an exact finite-sum identity over subsets of $\mathcal{P}_M$. Theorem 2 shows $\rho_k(M) \to P_M$ at fixed M with explicit rate. Theorem 4 sharpens this to a full asymptotic

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equivalence at fixed M, with explicit geometric rate controlled by the ratio $q^{**}(M)/q^{*}(M)$ of the second-largest to largest single-prime coprime densities. Theorem 5 establishes the sharp joint-scaling equivalence $\ln M \cdot (\rho_{\lfloor cM \rfloor}(M) - P_M)/P_M \to A(c) := \sum_{j\geq 1} e^{-cj} \ln(1 + 1/j)$. The key new ingredient for Theorem 5 is the geometric-mean bound $\beta_T^k \leq \prod_{p\in T} q_p^{k/|T|}$ (Lemma 10), which permits control of the multi-prime corrections uniformly in the size of the subset. Proposition 6 gives the $c \to 0^+$ and $c \to \infty$ asymptotics of A. Numerical computation up to $M = 10^7$ illustrates Theorem 5. The regime studied here is complementary to the classical fixed-k random-LCM literature; the exact subset identity (Theorem 1) may be of independent use in related problems involving multiplicative functions of random LCMs.

Data and code availability. Source code, random seeds, and raw numerical output for all figures and tables are openly available at `https://github.com/Wakid90/coprime-density-lcm`.

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